Origins of Dragons

A literature Review by :
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Thesis

The cross-cultural prevalence of dragons is best understood not as the result of a single origin, but as the intersection of evolutionary cognition, environmental influences, symbolic systems, and historical interactions, demonstrating the need for a multi-framework anthropological approach to myth analysis.

Research Questions

1) How do Scholars explain the cross-cultural emergency of dragons?
2) What do these explanations say about the human relationship to the how humans perceive the world around us?



Methodology

- Conduct a cross cultural analysis of four individual cultures
  - Western Europe
  - The Mediterranean
  - East Asia
  - Mesoamerica
- Gather as much as I can and Identify the Biases within them

Analysis Frameworks

Cognitive

The Evolutionary Psychology behind it

Symbology

The structural parts of society that built the connection



Ecology

The environment around that shapes how people see the world

Diffusion

The interconnectivity between cultures

01

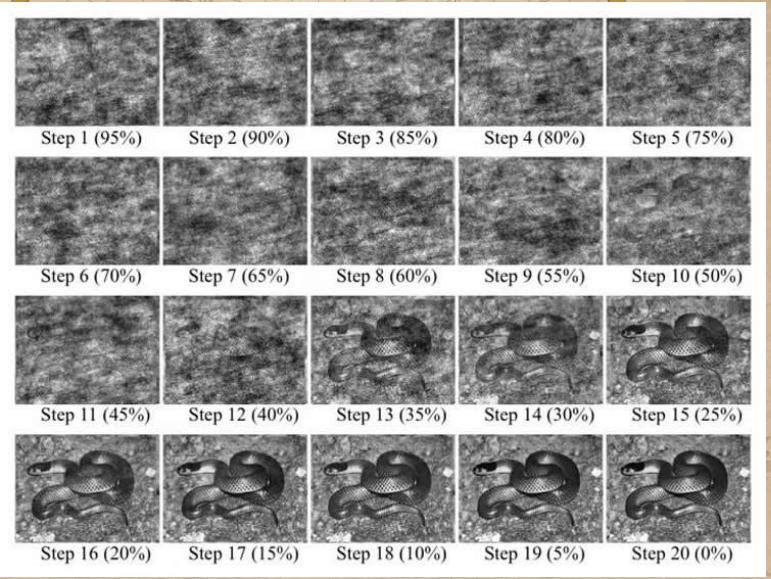
Cognitive

The Psychological Approach



Psychology

- "Predator Template" (Jones 2002)
  - Cognitive Universal
  - Cultural Combination of snakes, raptors, and large carnivores
- Humans' natural aptitude for detecting snakes (Kawai, Nobuki, and Hongshen He. 2016)



02

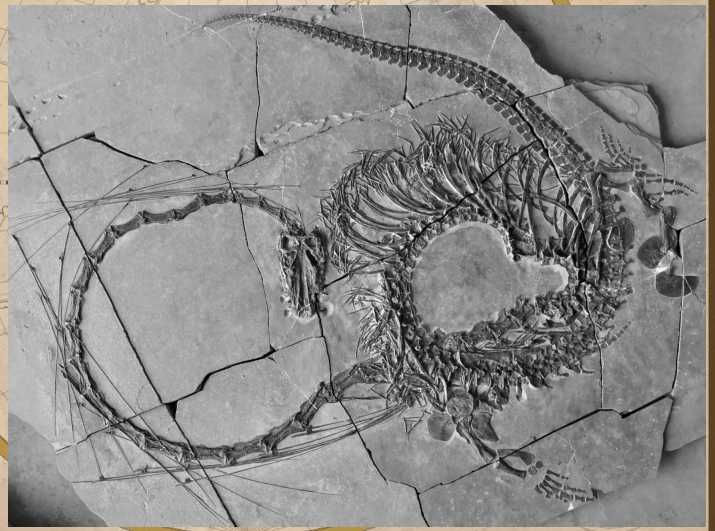
Ecology

The environment around people shaping their view



Fossils

- Finding Fossils for most of our history, but not knowing what they were
- *Dinocephalosaurus orientalis* found off the coast of southwestern China in 2003 (Spikeman, Stephan N.F., Wang, Wei, Zhao, Lijun, Rieppel, Oliver, Fraser, Nicholas C. and Li, Chun. 2024.)



Living Animals

- Mediterranean sea serpent sightings most likely being whale penises (Jones 2002)
- Mesoamerican Amphitheres being chaotic sightings of rows of birds through canopy's

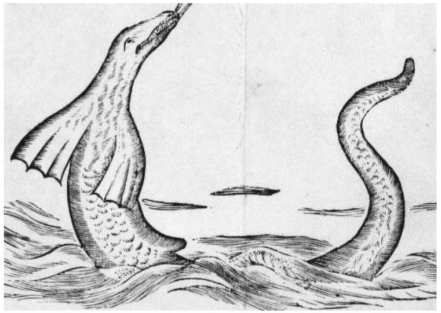


Figure 2. The creature as depicted in P. Egede (1741) (see Figure 1). Enlarged.



Figure 3. The figure of the serpent-like tail from the map (see Figure 1) in P. Egede (1741). Enlarged.





03

Symbology

The cultural components that shape a society's worldview



Cultural Dichotomy





Western Europe

In Medieval Europe, Dragons were paragons of sin, representing nature's wrath and social chaos

(Kahlifa-Gueta 2018)

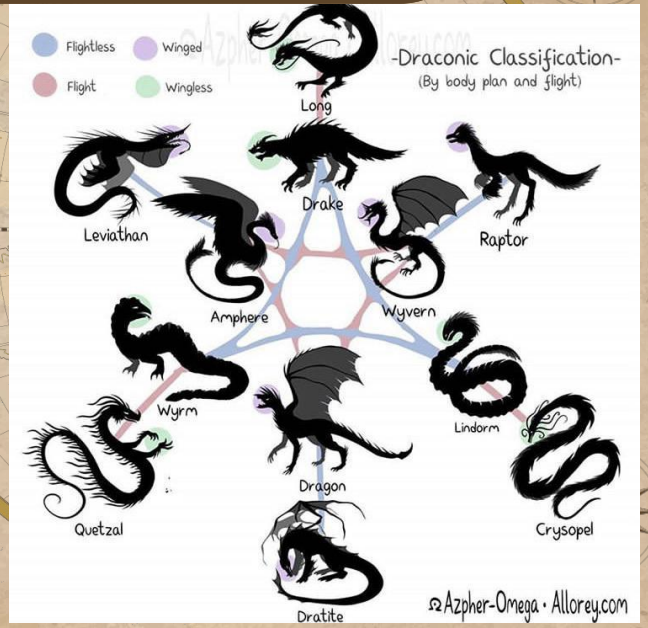
Eastern Asia

In China, Dragons were representations of Empyreal Power, and Symbols of Harmony

(Zhang 2024)

Explanations for the world

- In Japan, dragons are closely associated with storms and water (Izotova, 2024)
- In the Mediterranean the sea serpents were associated with chaotic waters (Núñez et al., 2015)
- In Mesoamerica, amphitheres are associated with winds and crop fertility (Jones 2002)



04

Diffusion

The Cultural Diffusionist approach

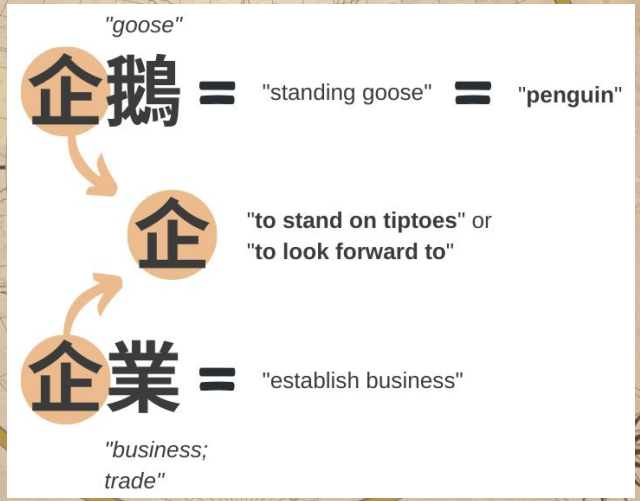


Cultural Diffusion

- The spread of artifacts, knowledge, and ideas between people among different cultures, which then spreads and gets integrated into the culture of origin
- Posits that the spread of dragons and their similarities follow contact points, and trade roots
    - The Mediterranean serpent myths are consistent with the exchanges that had been taking place between the Near East, North Africa, and Southern Europe (Kahlifa-Gueta 2018)

Language Translation

- Language translation is not an exact ‘science’ (Luo, Ni 2002)
- Semantic Translation
  - Tries to keep the syntactic structures of the second, to allow for an exact translation of the original
- Communicative Translation
  - Takes in the whole message of what’s being said, and presents it in the way the second language understands





Which is it?



Significance

A case study in how similar phenomonea can origionate cross-culturally

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